

Sarah L Kiefer

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EDUCATION

Ph.D. in Psychology

Expected 2027

Department of Cognitive & Psychological Sciences, Brown University, Providence, RI
Advisor: Dr. David Sobel

Sc. M. in Cognitive Science

May 2024

Department of Cognitive, Linguistic & Psychological Sciences, Brown University, Providence, RI
Thesis: "I Wanted to Challenge Myself!": Children's Developing Metacognitive Understanding of Effort in a Building Task
Committee: Dr. David Sobel (Chair), Dr. Daphna Buchsbaum, Dr. Amitai Shenhav

Bachelor of Science, Psychology (Psychological Science)

May 2019

College of Liberal Arts and Sciences, Arizona State University, Tempe, AZ

PUBLICATIONS

*MENTORED STUDENT

Manuscripts in Preparation and Under Review

Kiefer, S. L., Sobel, D. M. (in press). Children's decision to challenge themselves on a novel task relates to their metacognitive monitoring of their ability. *Child Development*.

Kiefer, S. L., Modesti, G., McHugh, S., & Sobel, D. M. (in prep). Fostering STEM engagement in spatial thinking from parent-child interaction in preschoolers: A remote study.

McHugh, S., Modesti, G., **Kiefer, S. L.**, & Sobel, D. M. (in progress). Parent-child interaction and children's learning and engagement with engineering principles. Brown University.

McHugh, S. R., **Kiefer, S. L.**, Modesti, G., & Sobel, D. M. (in progress). Children's developing understanding of science as a process. Brown University

Peer-Reviewed

Vaisarova, J., **Kiefer, S. L.**, Şen, H., Todd, P. M., & Lucca, K. (2024). Where should I search next? Messages embedded in storybooks influence children's strategic exploration in Turkey and the United States. *Journal of Experimental Psychology: General*, 153(8), 2174–2192.
<https://doi.org/10.1037/xge0001619>

Şen, H. H., **Kiefer, S. L.**, Aksu, E., Lucca, K. (2024). Developmental differences in children and adults' enforcement of explore versus exploit search strategies in the United States and Turkey. *Developmental Science*, e13520. <https://doi.org/10.1111/desc.13520>

Kiefer, S. L., Caballero, A.*, Lucca, K. (2023). The role of effort type and intensity in children's decisions about effort-based outcomes. *Infant and Child Development*.
<http://doi.org/10.1002/icd.2440>

Matthews, N. L., Smith, C. J., Skepnek, E., Mammen, M., James, J. S., Malligo, A., Lyon, A., Mitchell, M., **Kiefer, S. L.**, Smith, C. J. (2021). Feasibility and acceptability of a telehealth model for autism diagnostic evaluations in children, adolescents, and adults. *Autism Research*. DOI: 10.1002/aur.2591

Matthews, N. L., Christenson, K., **Kiefer, S.**, Smith, C. J. (2019). A Mixed-Methods Examination of the Gap between IQ and Adaptive Functioning in Autistic Young Adults without Intellectual Disability. *Autism*. DOI: 10.1177/13623613211018334

CONFERENCE PRESENTATIONS

*MENTORED STUDENT

Oral Presentations

Kiefer, S. L., Sobel, D. M. (2025, May). Children's decisions about difficulty during novel tasks relate to their metacognitive monitoring of their ability. *Talk presented at the Society for Research in Child Development*. Minneapolis, MN, USA.

Kiefer, S. L., Caballero, A.*, Lucca, K. (2022, November). The role of effort type and intensity in children's decision making. *Flash talk at the 3rd annual workshop on mental effort*. Providence, RI, USA.

Poster Presentations

Kiefer, S.L., Vezina, O.*, Sobel, D. M. (2025, May). "That was easy!" Children's definitions and examples of easy and hard experiences. *Poster presented at the Society for Research in Child Development*. Minneapolis, MN, USA.

Kiefer, S. L., Sobel, D. M. (2024, March). "I wanted to challenge myself!": Children's developing metacognitive understanding of effort allocation in a building task. *Poster presentation at the Cognitive Development Society Biennial Meeting*. Pasadena, CA, USA.

Vaisarova, J. (presenting author), **Kiefer, S. L.**, Şen, H. H., Todd, P., & Lucca, K. (2024, March). Where Should I Look Next? Using a Storybook Intervention to Promote Children's Strategic Exploration in a Virtual Search Task Across Cultures. *Poster presentation at the Cognitive Development Society Biennial Meeting*. Pasadena, CA, USA.

Özalp, D., **Kiefer, S. L.**, Uğur, G., Hanım Sancar, B., Ateş, S., Selalmaz, E., Uçal, A., Nur Deveci, A., Akpınar, B., Karaoğlu, M., Şen, H. (presenting author), Lucca, K. (2023, January). Associations between mothers' and children's curiosity in the Turkish context. *Poster Presentation at the Budapest CEU Conference on Cognitive Development*. Budapest, Hungary.

Kiefer, S. L., Caballero, A.*, Lucca, K. (2022, November). The role of effort type and intensity in children's decision making. *Poster presentation at the 3rd annual workshop on mental effort*. Providence, RI, USA.

Johns, A. (presenting author), Anbar, J., **Kiefer, S. L.**, Smith, C. J. (2022, May). Building inclusive informal STEM learning opportunities for people with ASD. *International Society for Autism Research Annual Meeting*. Austin, TX, USA.

Kiefer, S. L., Şen, H., Akpınar, B., Smith, B.*, Nur Deveci, A., Selalmaz, E., Snodgrass, N.*, Özalp, D., Patel, S.*, Uçal, A., Lucca, K. (2022, April). Navigating the explore-exploit dilemma: a cross-cultural examination of 3–6-year-olds' own behavioral strategies and enforcement of strategies onto others. *Poster presentation at the Cognitive Development Society Biennial Meeting*. Madison, WI, USA.

Kiefer, S. L., Caballero, A.*, Lucca, K. (2022, April). Worth the wait: the role of cognitive and physical effort in shaping children's value judgments, preferences, and behavior. *Poster presentation at the Cognitive Development Society Biennial Meeting*. Madison, WI, USA.

Saguid, L.*(presenting author), Johnson, N.*, **Kiefer, S.**, Scirpo, K.*, Patel, S.*, Hinojosa, A.*, Snodgrass, N.*, Kupfer, A., Lucca, K. (2021, September). Investigating the relations between early creativity, confidence, curiosity, and persistence. *Poster presentation at the Marconi Institute for Creativity Conference*. Online.

Christenson, K., **Kiefer, S.**, Tracey, S., Matthews, N. L., & Smith, C. J. (2019, May). A qualitative examination of the transportation experiences and needs of young adults with ASD without intellectual disability. *Poster presentation at the International Society for Autism Research Annual Meeting*. Montreal, Quebec, Canada.

INVITED TALKS

Kiefer, S., L. (2025, November). Unpacking children's understanding of productive failure in learning and persistence. Invited speaker for the Developmental Brown Bag, Brown University.

Kiefer, S., L. (2022, January). Clues to Explore: The Effects of Linguistic Priming on Children's Exploration in an Online Search Task. Invited speaker for Cognition and Learning Center, Rutgers University.

HONORS AND AWARDS

Peter D. Eimas Graduate Research Award, Brown's Department of Cognitive and Psychological Sciences, 2025.

NSF Graduate Research Fellowship Program Honorable Mention, 2024.

Graduate Conference Travel Award, Brown University. 2024, 2025.

MEDIA COVERAGE

Ewing, R. (2022, August 15) Emerging Minds Lab receives NSF CAREER grant to expand access to research. *ASU News*. Available at <https://news.asu.edu/20220815-emerging-minds-lab-receives-nsf-career-grant-expand-access-research>

Greguska, E. (2021, April 6). Tiny volunteers help ASU lab study curiosity. *ASU News*. Available at <https://news.asu.edu/20210405-solutions-baby-einsteins>

PRE-DOCTORAL RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

[Emerging Minds Lab](#) | PI: Dr. Kelsey Lucca | Tempe, AZ

June 2021 – June 2022 | **Lab Manager**

Feb. 2020 – June 2021 | **Project Coordinator**

Oct. 2019 – Feb. 2020 | **Research Assistant**

[Southwest Autism Research and Resource Center \(SARRC\)](#) | Phoenix, AZ

Jan. 2021 – May 2021 | **Research Study Coordinator**

Dec. 2018 – Dec. 2020 | **Research Study Recruiter**

May 2018 – May 2019 | **Research Intern**

[REACH Institute, Bridges to High School Program](#) | PI: Dr. Nancy Gonzales | Tempe, AZ

Jan. 2018 – May 2019 | **Data Management Research Assistant & Phone Interviewer**

Aug 2017 – Dec. 2017 | **In-home Interviewer**

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

Teaching Assistant

Fall 2025 Social and Moral Development

Spring 2025 Children's Thinking: The Nature of Cognitive Development

Summer 2024 Psychology Across Species, [Summer@Brown](#) pre-college program

Spring 2024 Statistical Methods

Guest Lectures

Feb. 2025 Children's Thinking: The Nature of Cognitive Development
Brown University, Dr. Dave Sobel

Sept. 2021 Cognitive Development
Arizona State University, Dr. Kelsey Lucca

Feb. 2020 Cognitive Development
Arizona State University, Dr. Kelsey Lucca

MENTORING EXPERIENCE

[Undergraduate Teaching and Research Award](#): Students Supervised

- Katherine Kupsaw, Brown University (Spring 2024)
- Seidy Idris, Brown University (Spring 2024)

Honors Students Supervised

- Nicole Johnson, Arizona State University, 2021-2022
 - Recipient of the Barrett Honors College Thesis Funding Award
- Kaitlin Van Houghton, Arizona State University, 2021-2022
 - Recipient of the Barrett Honors College Thesis Funding Award

- Sonia Patel, Arizona State University, 2021-2022
 - Recipient of the Barrett Honors College Thesis Funding Award
- Kalie Scirpo, Arizona State University, 2020-2021
 - Recipient of the Barrett Honors College Thesis Funding Award

PROFESSIONAL SKILLS

Programming: Proficiency in R, Jamovi, JASP, SPSS. Some proficiency in JSON (i.e., for programming experiments on childrenhelpingscience.com)

Computer/Web Applications: Adobe Suite (Illustrator, Photoshop), Squarespace, Datavyu, Salesforce, REDCap, Qualtrics, MTurk

Administration of behavioral experiments with children: over 600 participants tested to date.

Assessments: Experienced in administering cognitive and behavioral assessments with individuals throughout the lifespan, including the Mullen Scales of Early Learning and the Kaufman Brief Intelligence Test. Received extensive training on the Autism Diagnostic Observation Schedule, Autism Diagnostic Interview-Revised, Preschool Language Scales, and Wechsler Intelligence Scale for Children (full certification not complete due to COVID-19 interruptions).

ACADEMIC SERVICE

Spring 2024 – Present	Diversity and Inclusion Action Plan Committee, Community Outreach Subcommittee, Department of Cognitive, Linguistic & Psychological Sciences at Brown University
Fall 2023 – Spring 2024	Graduate Student Council Representative for the Department of Cognitive, Linguistic & Psychological Sciences at Brown University

PROFESSIONAL AFFILIATIONS AND WORKSHOPS

Spring 2025 - Present	Member of the Society for Research in Child Development
Spring 2022 - Present	Member of the Cognitive Development Society
Summer 2023	Computational Cognitive Models of Learning and Development Workshop – Harvard University
Fall 2021 and Fall 2022	Workshop on Mental Effort
Spring 2019 – Spring 2020	Member of the International Society for Autism Research

COMMUNITY ENGAGEMENT

Spring 2023, 2024	College Day at Brown facilitator for the Department of Cognitive & Psychological Sciences
Spring 2023 – Fall 2024	In collaboration with Dr. Amitai Shenhav, facilitated motivation and effort guest lessons for 4 th graders at William D'Abate Elementary in Providence. We visited weekly across four weeks with two cohorts of 4 th graders.